constituency offered the sole bright spot for the BJP as its candidate Dnyaneshwar Mhatre won against Balaram Patil of the Peasants and Workers Party (PWP), an MVA constituent. Nashik, too, bucked the trend as Congress rebel Satyajeet Tambe easily overcame the Shiv Sena and MVA-supported independent Shubhangi Patil.

Of course, more than the fate of the individual candidates, it's the overall message that should worry the BJP. A senior party leader concedes that the setback is a reflection of organisational disarray. "These elections are not a test of the candidate's popularity, but a mandate on the health of the organisation. The defeat shows that the party has fallen short," he admits, ruefully.

There is jubilation in the rival camp—its leaders were quick to extrapolate from this turn of events. "This is a resounding victory for the MVA. This shows the educated class has rejected the BJP and the policies of the Union and state governments," says Ambadas Danve of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), leader of the opposition in the legislative council.

For all the grandiose statements, the fact is the results have come as a pleasant surprise to the MVA. The rainbow coalition had come across as a divided house when it came to planning and strategising. The Congress and the MVA were caught napping, for instance, when Satyajeet Tambe, maternal nephew of Congress legislature party chief and ex-revenue minister Balasaheb Thorat, rebelled in Nashik. Satyajeet's father Dr Sudhir Tambe, a sitting three-term legislator from the constituency, had opted out of the contest at the last minute, choosing instead to field his son as an independent.

All the signs of impending trouble had been there. The Tambe move was the culmination of a power feud with Thorat, say the ex-minister's adversaries within the party. He was said to be promoting his daughter Dr Jayashree. The BJP,

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The MVA wins come in seats that are part of 24% in the council where the electorate is made up of teachers or graduates



DHIRAJ LINGADE (Congress): Amravati graduates' constituency



VIKRAM KALE (NCP): Aurangabad teachers' constituency



DNYANESHWAR MHATRE (BJP): Konkan teachers' constituency



SATYAJEET TAMBE (Ind.) Nashik graduates' constituency



SUDHAKAR ADBALE (Vidarbha Madhyamik Shikshak Sangh and Congress): Nagpur teachers' constituency

JHARKHAND/ BJP VS SOREN

THE SLUGFEST SEASON

By Amitabh Srivastava

On February 4, as Chief Minister Hemant Soren was celebrating his party Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM)'s 51st Foundation Day in Dhanbad, Union home minister Amit Shah came down heavily on his government—calling it the "most corrupt in the country"—while



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